MAHARASHTRA

All Is Not Well Between Shinde And Fadnavis

By Dhaval Kulkarni

For legislators of the ruling Balasahebanchi Shiv Sena (BSS)-BJP coalition in Maharashtra, every day might bring reminders of that famous dialogue—"*taarikh pe taarikh*" (one date after the other)—from the 1990s potboiler *Damini*. That's because these MLAs, in contention for ministerial berths in the proposed expansion of the Eknath Shinde government, are being regularly given fresh deadlines for this exercise. The new ministers were to be inducted before the winter session of the assembly at Nagpur, but this deadline too was missed. More to the point, it seems just a surface symptom: insiders say the delay points to simmering tensions between the allies on power-sharing and division of portfolios, with internal restiveness within each constituent adding to the unstable mix.

One sign of trouble within the ruling coalition: corruption allegations against CM Shinde and ministers from his camp during the winter session. Tellingly, the key question being raised was whether it was an inside job. Senior BJP leaders are adding a spritz of fuel to the simmering coal, not exactly being covert about their continuing unhappiness at the party letting Shinde walk off with the CM's chair. Moreover, it was only on August 9—40 days after Shinde and Fadnavis took oath on June 30—that the cabinet was expanded with 18 ministers, nine each from BSS and BJP. The state cabinet can have 43 members, including the chief minister. The second



WHOSE MOVE? CM Eknath Shinde with deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis

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